

A. M. Dimuthu Chathurika Attanayake

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Authorized to work in the US (STEM OPT)

WORK

Research Assistant

Spring 2026 Semester

Department of Knight Chair of Data Journalism, Columbia Journalism School

- Researching and building agentic AI tools to assist newsroom pipelines

Journalist

June 2021 – August 2025

Sri Lanka contributor to the South China Morning Post, Contributor to Business Matters, World Business Report on BBC World Service, Foreign Policy, Thomson Reuters Foundation News, Guardian, Deutsche Welle, Nikkei Asia and Rest of World.

- **Industry and market coverage:** [plastic trade](#) and maritime spills in Asia, challenges in [garment manufacturing](#), and [BYD](#) market in Sri Lanka.
- **Tech:** How [social media](#) helped Sri Lankans source essentials during the Sri Lankan economic crisis, Sri Lankan tech industry's attempt to [retain talent](#) during the rupee crash.
- Covered the Sri Lanka [economic crisis](#) from beginning to the end, as it evolved into a [political](#), [socio-economic](#) and [medical crisis](#), and then onboarded the country's 17th [IMF](#) programme.
- Reporting from the UN headquarters in NYC in 2024, the [summit of the future](#), UN General Assembly, Security Council, High level meetings and one on one interviews with high level officials.
- **Geopolitics:** [India and China](#) geopolitical rivalry, [Sri Lanka's role](#) in US operation against Yemen's Houthi rebels in 2024, India's interest in [cobalt](#) in Sri Lanka's continental shelf.
- **Environment and climate change:** how climate change exacerbate [gender based economic violence](#), destructive [blast fishing in Asia and Africa](#), Ecocide caused by [Xpress Pearl Maritime Disaster](#), how black tipped reef sharks in French Polynesia survive climate change.

Junior Researcher – Data, Algorithms and Policy

Sep 2020 – Sep 2021

LIRNEasia, Sri Lanka

- Developed AI tools for fact-checking, extended literature review on information disorder, project management.

Business Adviser

Oct 2019 – Aug 2020

Market Development Facility (Australian Aid), Palladium Group SL (Pvt) Ltd, Sri Lanka

- Performed qualitative and quantitative economic analysis on value chains to design market interventions.
- Negotiated, developed and managed partnerships with identified private/public sector entities.
- Advised the economic and technical feasibility of business plans with potential partners; advised the country director on selected value chains; contributed to research assessing investment portfolio performance and beneficiaries; developed results measurement techniques.

Journalist

Feb 2016 – Sep 2019

- Environment, Social issues, and Business reporter for National English Language newspapers in Sri Lanka including the Sunday Observer, Nation and Ceylon Today.

EDUCATION

MS in Data Journalism candidate – Columbia University

- Produced a responsive data story on how 'dirty' the energy used to train AI models by the top 8 AI developing destinations, with pandas and datawrapper, powered by ai2html and GitHub actions.
- Final Project (ongoing) an investigation of global plastic trade and maritime environmental pollution

B.Sc. (Hons) Economics and Finance – University of London

AWARDS AND RECOGNITION

- Winner – Developing Asia Journalism Awards 2024, Asia Development Bank Institute
- Honorable Mention - AAJA 2026 Excellence in Written Reporting, Features Award
- Reham Al-Farra Memorial Journalism Fellow, United Nations, 2024, New York
- Pulitzer Center Grantee, 2023
- Falling Walls Journalist Fellow, 2022, Berlin
- Top 12 International Young Journalists shortlisted for the Young Journalist Award 2018, Thomson Foundation & Foreign Press Association, London

TRAINING

- Reporting on Social Inclusion in South Asia – Thomson Reuters Foundation & ADB, 2022
- Media Workshop on Neglected Tropical Diseases for Asian Science & Health Journalists – DNDi/MSF, Bangkok, 2022
- Global Investigative Journalism Conference 2023 & SKUP International Investigative Masterclass, Sweden

SKILLS

- Pandas, HTML, CSS, D3, Svelte, SQL
- Visualization: Datawrapper, ai2html, Adobe Illustrator, scrollytelling
- Motion graphics: After Effects
- QGIS